

ER OON Operating Model 2027: Model A vs Model B

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Summary

Both models keep 10 full-cycle teams in Lebanon and meet the January 1, 2027 deadline, when the IDR Gateway becomes US-only. They differ in how Gateway filing is done. **Model A** (people-first) hires a 7-person US Gateway Desk that types prepared disputes into the Gateway. **Model B** (automation-first) has Lebanon deliver ready-to-file bundles and AI drafts, so a 3-person US desk files them through a Submission Cockpit.

Model B saves about **\$140,000–160,000 a year** today and **\$409,000–499,000 a year** by year two. In exchange, it depends on new software, a legal and Gateway-terms check, and a very small US team. Neither model includes recruiting fees or infrastructure costs: we recruit in-house and run on systems and equipment we already have.

Recommendation: go live on January 1 with Model A, then earn Model B in stages. Pilot the Cockpit in February and step down to 3 US staff only after its gates pass. If a gate fails, we stay on Model A at no extra cost.

At a glance

Model B wins on cost, speed and coverage; Model A wins on readiness, resilience and simplicity.

	Model A: people-first	Model B: automation-first	Edge
Lebanon structure	10 full-cycle teams, 94 people, plus a 2-lead bridge shift	Same 10 teams; 4 existing staff form an Automation Cell, including the 2 bridge leads	Even
US Gateway desk	7: 1 working lead, 6 associates, typing from ClickUp tickets	3: 1 Submission Lead, 2 Specialists, filing from bundles in a Cockpit	B

	Model A: people-first	Model B: automation-first	Edge
Total headcount today	101	97	B
Filing time per dispute	About 47 minutes	Target of 10 minutes	B
US hours covered	One US day shift; bridge shift 12:00–20:00 Beirut	12 hours, 7:00–19:00 Central, in 3 staggered shifts	B
Use of AI	Medical-necessity reports with an approved LLM tool	Also drafts packets and offers, and reads determinations overnight	B
Lebanon specialists by year two	About 125	About 102 (23 fewer hires)	B
New software	None; configuration in ClickUp	Submission Cockpit and form filler, built in-house	A
Ready for January 1	Yes	No; runs on Model A's desk until Gate 2 (April 30, 2027)	A
Outside approvals	Legal sign-off on the onshore rule	Also written confirmation that the Gateway allows assisted form filling	A
Absence cover on the US desk	One absence removes 1 of 7 people	One absence removes 1 of 3 people	A
Pay extras	Badge allowances, quarterly bonus, bridge incentive	Adds team gainshare, bounty board, automation allowance	Depends

Model A: people-first

Model A replaces 12 facility teams with 10 full-cycle teams and moves Gateway entry to a 7-person US desk. Lebanon prepares every dispute; the US desk only enters it. Nobody is laid off and no one's pay goes down.

- **One owner per account:** each RCM Specialist works an account from coding to final payment, replacing the coder, biller and negotiator handoffs.

- **Payer portfolios, not facilities:** work is balanced by effort in three tiers, and new facilities join existing teams.
- **US Gateway Desk:** 1 working lead and 6 associates enter prepared ClickUp tickets and make no pricing decisions. A 2-lead bridge shift (12:00–20:00 Beirut) fixes tickets the same day.
- **Careers:** one role with four levels (L1–L4) earned through nine skill badges, with specialist pay of \$1,000–2,000 a month.
- **Growth:** the US desk scales on a backlog trigger, to about 12 people in year one and 18 in year two.

Model B: automation-first

Model B keeps Model A's teams, levels and pay bands, and cuts the US desk to 3 by sending it ready-to-file bundles instead of tickets.

- **Submission Cockpit:** a US operator opens a bundle on a company device, a helper fills the Gateway forms, and the operator checks every field and clicks submit personally. It is built in-house on our existing Google Workspace, starting from the IDR Prep Studio.
- **Dispute factory in Lebanon:** AI drafts packets, medical-necessity reports and offer letters, and specialists approve them. The target is 0.33 specialists per daily visit instead of 0.45.
- **Automation Cell:** 2 Automation Analysts and 2 Bundle QA Leads, all existing staff, own the templates, AI prompts and final check.
- **Pay on results:** a team gainshare pays 3% of recovery above baseline, capped at 15% of base pay. A bounty board pays for clearing claims over 90 days old.
- **12-hour US day:** three staggered shifts cover 7:00–19:00 Central, so work prepared in Lebanon is filed the same day.
- **Compliance guardrail:** only a US person on a US device acts in the Gateway. There is no mirroring, remote control or unattended submission.

Cost comparison

Model B costs about **\$140,000–160,000 a year less** at today's volume and **\$409,000–499,000 less** by year two. US figures are approximate Texas market rates for direct hires, plus 25% for benefits and payroll taxes; replace them with our own pay offers. No recruiting fees or infrastructure costs are included, because recruiting is in-house and both models run on systems and equipment we already have.

Annual cost (USD)	Model A	Model B	Model B saves
US desk today	7 people: 346,000–421,000	3 people with bonus (194,000–231,000) plus AI drafting (12,000–30,000): 206,000–261,000	140,000–160,000
Year 1 (about 4,400 disputes a month)	12 people: 580,000–707,000	5 people plus AI drafting: 331,000–408,000	249,000–299,000
Year 2 (about 6,500 disputes a month)	18 people: 861,000–1,050,000	7 people plus AI drafting: 452,000–551,000	409,000–499,000
One-time	Paid onboarding, November–December: 58,000–70,000	The same onboarding, since Model A's desk runs first; plus legal review of the Cockpit (quote needed)	Legal review only

Lebanon: Model A adds the bridge shift (up to \$6,000 a year) and advanced-badge allowances (\$45–70 per holder a month). Model B adds automation allowances (\$2,400 a year), the bounty board (up to \$150 per person a month) and the gainshare, which is funded from recovery above baseline. In return, AI drafting is targeted to avoid about 23 hires by year two, worth roughly \$380,000 a year.

Advantages and drawbacks

Model A is the safer way to meet January 1; Model B is the cheaper and faster way to run once it is proven.

Model A: people-first

Advantages

- Ready for January 1 with no new software: ClickUp tickets and the deadline engine are all it needs.
- A 7-person US desk absorbs absences, leave and volume spikes.
- Simple to explain and run; the US role is plain data entry and easy to hire for.

- Lower compliance exposure, since only legal sign-off on the onshore rule is needed.
- Pay changes are modest and predictable.

Drawbacks

- Highest running cost, growing almost in step with volume to \$861,000–1,050,000 a year by year two.
- About 47 minutes of manual typing per dispute, with more room for entry errors.
- US desk size depends heavily on whether the Gateway allows bulk upload.
- About 23 more Lebanon hires by year two than Model B.

Model B: automation-first

Advantages

- Saves \$140,000–160,000 a year now and \$409,000–499,000 by year two, and the gap widens with volume.
- Filing drops to a target of 10 minutes per dispute, and a 12-hour US day files Lebanon's work the same day.
- Two checks before filing: Bundle QA reviews every bundle, and the operator checks every field.
- AI drafting and the determination reader cut Lebanon workload and hiring.
- Gainshare and the bounty board reward recovery and clear aged claims.
- Builds on the IDR Prep Studio and systems we already own, so the up-front cost is small.

Drawbacks

- Depends on the Gateway's terms allowing assisted form filling; without it, most of the US saving disappears.
- A 3-person desk is fragile: one absence removes a third of capacity.
- New software to maintain, and Gateway screen changes can break its field mappings.
- AI drafts need constant specialist review and QA sampling.
- Gainshare could push aggressive settlements if its guardrails slip.
- More change for staff at once, on top of the team restructure.

Risks

Model A carries mainly volume and people risks; Model B adds technology, approval and concentration risks. The biggest single risk in Model B is that one absence leaves the US desk a third short.

Risk	Model	Likelihood	Impact	Response
We misread the Gateway's onshore rule	Both	Low	High	Legal sign-off before the build; offshore access stays as a fallback until December 19
People read new levels as a demotion	Both	Medium	Medium	Provisional levels, protected pay, published criteria, one appeal each
We lose IDR experts during the change	Both	Medium	High	Retention bonus through January 2028; an L4 path that doesn't require managing
The US desk falls behind as volume grows	A	Medium	High	Backlog trigger adds staff within 2 weeks; bridge leads report it daily
One US absence cuts capacity by a third	B	High	High	2 trained on-call staff, leave rules, kill switch on backlog
Gateway terms forbid the form filler	B	Medium	High	Gate 0 checks first; fall back to on-screen copy help and Model A staffing
AI drafts contain errors	B	Medium	High	A specialist approves every draft; QA samples AI output weekly
A bundle defect spreads to many disputes	B	Low	High	Bundle QA checks every bundle; analysts fix the template, not just the case
A Gateway screen change breaks the Cockpit	B	Medium	Medium	Analysts fix mappings within 1 day; manual entry is always available

Risk	Model	Likelihood	Impact	Response
The US team burns out at 40 disputes a shift	B	Medium	Medium	Quarterly bonus, remote work, review of the pace at Gate 2
Gainshare pushes aggressive settlements	B	Low	Medium	Cap, quality multiplier, unchanged decision rights

Recommendation and decisions

Start on Model A, then move to Model B only as each gate passes. The January 1 deadline never depends on new software, and every step can be reversed.

1. **October–December 2026:** hire the 7-person US desk in-house on 3–6 month contracts. Get legal sign-off and the Gateway terms check, and start the Cockpit from the IDR Prep Studio.
2. **Gate 0, November 30:** legal and the Gateway terms both say yes. If not, we stay on Model A.
3. **January 1, 2027:** go live on Model A's desk.
4. **February to mid-March:** pilot the Cockpit on 20%, then 50%, of volume.
5. **Gate 1, March 15:** 12 minutes or less per dispute, errors under 0.5%, 98% of bundles right first time, and no missed deadlines.
6. **March–April:** hire 3 permanent US staff in-house and let contracts end one at a time.
7. **Gate 2, April 30:** 4 weeks on 3 people with the backlog under 1 business day.
8. **May onward:** switch on the determination reader, then start gainshare and the bounty board in the third quarter.

Kill switches: we return to Model A staffing if any of these happens:

- The backlog stays above 1 business day for 5 days in a row.
- A deadline is missed because of the desk or a bundle.
- Errors stay above 1% for 2 weeks.
- The Gateway changes its terms or blocks the form filler.

In-house recruiting keeps a bench of pre-screened candidates so 4 people can start within 2 weeks.

Decisions requested:

- ☐ Approve Model A for January 1, with the US desk hired in-house on 3–6 month contracts.
- ☐ Approve building the Cockpit on our existing systems, and the Gate 0 legal and Gateway-terms review.
- ☐ Approve stepping down to Model B's 3-person desk only after Gates 1 and 2 pass.
- ☐ Approve the gainshare and bounty board from the third quarter of 2027, subject to Gate 2.